

CRM SETUP CHECKLIST

Choose and Implement a System Your Team Will Actually Use

A practical 3-phase framework for nonprofits and small businesses



If your Tech Health Check score was **4 or above**, here is exactly what is happening inside your organization right now.



Lost Revenue

Leads and donors slip away because no one tracked the follow-up or knew who was responsible.



Wasted Time

Your team spends hours a week on data entry and chasing information that should take minutes.



No Visibility

Leadership cannot see where things stand, so decisions get made on gut feel instead of real data.



Tools That Fail

You have tried software before and the team stopped using it. The problem was never the tool.

A CRM fixes all four of these, but only when it is set up correctly. Most implementations fail not because the software is bad, but because organizations skip the planning steps. This guide gives you the exact 3-phase process Ella Tech uses to get systems implemented, adopted, and generating results within 30 days.

Your 3-Week Path from Chaos to Clarity



CLARIFY

Define the real problem



EVALUATE

Choose the right tool



IMPLEMENT

Launch and get adoption

55%

of CRM projects fail to meet their goals

Vantage Point Research, 2025

#1

cause of failure is poor user adoption, not bad software

Radin Dynamics, 2025

\$8.71

returned for every \$1 invested when done right

Nucleus Research

30

days to full adoption when this process is followed

Ella Tech client average

Want to skip the DIY? Ella Tech Solutions works hands-on with nonprofits and small businesses to get this done for you. Turn to the last page to book your free discovery call, or visit ellatechsolutions.com.

PHASE 1 · CLARIFY YOUR NEEDS · Week 1

Before you look at a single CRM, get clear on what's broken. Vague problems produce wrong choices and wasted budgets.

1 | Define the Problem First

- ☐ Are you losing leads or opportunities?
- ☐ Excessive manual data entry?
- ☐ No pipeline or donor visibility?
- ☐ Data split across 3+ tools?
- ☐ Inconsistent or missed follow-ups?
- ☐ Leads lost per month: _____

Action:

Write your top 3 problems in one sentence each. This becomes your team's WHY, the reason they adopt instead of ignore.

2 | Assess Your Readiness

Score yourself, check every box. Your total tells you whether to proceed or fix gaps first.

Readiness Check

- ☐ You have a champion who will drive this forward
- ☐ Your team helped identify the problem you're solving
- ☐ Someone is designated to own the system daily
- ☐ Your existing data is clean enough to migrate
- ☐ Budget covers software + setup + training
- ☐ Your team is open to learning new tools

NOT READY (0-2)

PROCEED WITH CAUTION (3-4)

READY TO IMPLEMENT (5-6)

← Score yourself on the readiness checklist above →

Red Flag:

Score below 5? Pause. Address gaps before spending on software. A CRM without these foundations fails every time.

3 | Define What Success Looks Like

Answer these before you sign any contract:

Success Question	Your Answer
How many leads/contacts will it track?	_____
#1 task it must make faster or easier?	_____
Team adoption target (% daily in 30 days)?	_____
Key metric that proves it's working?	_____
Total realistic budget (software + training)?	\$ _____

55% of CRM implementations fail to meet planned objectives Vantage Point Research, 2025	\$8.71 average return for every \$1 invested in CRM when done right Nucleus Research	27% average improvement in customer retention with proper CRM use Capterra / Nucleus Research
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PHASE 2 · EVALUATE & CHOOSE · Week 2

You know your problem. Now find the tool that fits, without being sold features you will never use.

4 | Must-Have vs. Nice-to-Have Features

✓ Must-Have (non-negotiable)	○ Nice-to-Have (bonus, not dealbreaker)
Lead and contact tracking	Advanced customization
Pipeline or relationship visibility	AI-powered lead scoring
Email and calendar integration	Social media feed integration
Task and follow-up reminders	Built-in marketing email blasts
Basic reporting you can act on	Complex automated workflow builders
Easy data export, you own it	Predictive analytics

5 | Compare Your Top 3 Tools

Fill this in for each CRM you're evaluating:

Criteria	Tool A	Tool B	Tool C
Has ALL must-have features?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Total cost (software + training)?	\$_____	\$_____	\$_____
Free trial or demo available?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Team learns without IT support?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
You own and can export your data?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Month-to-month contract option?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No
Quality customer support?	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No	☐ Yes ☐ No



Decision Rule:

Don't pick the most features. Pick what checks all your must-haves at a budget you can sustain. Simple tools get used. Complex ones collect dust.

6 | Lock In Team Buy-In Before You Sign

Buy-In Check
☐ Your team knows which CRM you're choosing, and why
☐ Your champion is genuinely excited, not just compliant
☐ Budget has been formally approved
☐ Implementation support or training is part of the deal
☐ Contract terms reviewed (cancel anytime? Data export included?)

PHASE 3 · IMPLEMENT & ADOPT · Week 3

The tool is chosen. This is where implementations live or die. Follow this sequence, do not skip steps.

55%

of CRM projects fail to achieve their planned objectives

Vantage Point Research, 2025

\$8.71

returned for every \$1 invested when implemented correctly

Nucleus Research

Why most projects fail at this stage:

- Poor user adoption is the #1 cause of CRM failure, cited in nearly 50% of cases
- Inadequate training is the most common root cause of low adoption
- Teams that skip structured rollout see significantly lower long-term usage
- The #1 difference between success and failure is not the software. It is the process behind it.

Sources: Vantage Point Research (2025); Radin Dynamics (2025); Symbiosis International University (2025)

7 | Setup: Days 1–3

Day	Task	Owner	✓
1	Complete initial config: fields, pipelines, basic flows	Admin	☐
1	Appoint system admin (owns daily management)	Director	☐
2	Migrate and clean existing data: contacts, leads, history	Admin	☐
2	Set up email and calendar integrations	Admin	☐
3	Build 1-page quick-start guide for your team	Admin	☐
3	Run 15-min walkthrough with each team member	Champion	☐

⚠ Don't over-customize yet.

Start simple. Solve the one problem from Phase 1. Add features after adoption, never before.

8 | Training: Days 4–7

- ☐ 45–60 min group training (max)
- ☐ Lead with the problem, not the software
- ☐ Use real data, their actual contacts
- ☐ Have a peer demo the core workflow
- ☐ Hands-on practice (not just watching)
- ☐ Admin holds office hours for week 1

The Mindset Shift:

You're not teaching software. You're showing your team how this tool makes their specific job easier, starting with the problem they already feel.

9 | The 30-Day Check-In

Metric	Target	Your Result
Daily CRM usage by team	80%+	_____
Leads/contacts logged consistently	80%+	_____
Original problem improved?	Yes	☐ Yes ☐ Partial
Team satisfaction with the tool?	Positive	_____
Pipeline/donor visibility clear?	Yes	☐ Yes ☐ No

THE GOLDEN RULE

Your CRM will only be as good as the process and training behind it.

The tool doesn't fail. The approach fails. Every decision traces back to one question: does this solve the specific problem you defined in Phase 1?

If yes, keep going. If no, stop and re-align.

When You Hit a Wall

Problem	Root Cause	Fix
Team won't use it	No clear WHY	Return to Phase 1. Reconnect to the problem.
Data is a mess	Skipped data audit	Pause. Clean before migrating, not after.
Wrong features	No must-have list	Re-evaluate now. Cut losses early.
Only 1 person using it	No champion	Appoint admin, re-run team training.
Can't tell if it's working	No success metrics	Define them now. Start 30-day check-in.

READY FOR HANDS-ON HELP?

This checklist gives you the framework. Implementation is where it gets complicated: data cleanup, team resistance, configuration choices, training design. These take time and expertise.

Ella Tech Solutions works hands-on with nonprofits and small businesses to get CRMs implemented, adopted, and generating real results within 30 days. Not just set up. Actually used.



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